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I tested the MoneyHelper Pensions Dashboard beta. Here's what I found

MHPD is in its second phase of consumer testing before the October connection deadline



Alex Levy

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Hello and Welcome to the
Professional Pensions Help Desk.



Image: The MoneyHelper Pensions Dashboard is now easier to test yourself (iStock.com/WhiteTea)

Having joined the industry only recently, the Pensions Dashboard Programme (PDP) seemed to me like something of a white whale for pension professionals. An enormous feat of data work, combining 70 million records from 1,500 providers and schemes, in pursuit of ever-elusive member engagement and progress on retirement adequacy.

After industry expert testing and an initial unmoderated rounds of consumer testing from March of this year, access to the Money Helper Pensions Dashboard (MHPD) has been simplified and expanded since 1 September.

While still under further development and with testing volume set to increase, anyone over 18 who has not yet withdrawn from all their pensions can [sign up for a first glimpse](#) at the results of this herculean cross-industry effort – namely, all your pensions in one place.

Logging in

Accessing the beta dashboard requires proving your address, photo identification, and where applicable, your national insurance number. For those 23 million users already registered with a GOV.UK One Login, the process is quicker.

But as [one LinkedIn commenter](#) said: "My biggest frustration is the sign-up process. Yet another government ID I never knew I needed (I already have at least two) and yet another selfie validation app I don't want to install."

Once logged in I received a disclaimer noting the values would be estimates, shown before tax and subject to contributions and investment performance. The system proceeds to track down your pensions, with a wait of up to 65 seconds.

I saw with a thrill that two pensions had been found: my workplace defined contribution (DC) policy and state pension.

The dashboard

The prompt 'Are you expecting to see other pensions?' appears at this point, guiding users to contact employers check for refunded pensions, provide their National Insurance number or check back later, among other options.

Clicking through, if I had a more fragmented set of pensions, I might expect to see a "pension pending" notification, SIPPs, or defined benefit (DB) plans within my portfolio.

As it was, I was shown the estimated monthly income I could expect to receive at retirement from my two combined pensions, alongside an approximate annual figure.

For each pension in my estimate, I was shown monthly and annual income, as well as the pot's current value and expected growth. There is also a timeline to show how this income might change based on the retirement date for each pension.

Further information is provided within each pension, pointing you to annual reports, investment strategies, and helpful links to contact the provider directly, such as in the case of 'missing' pensions which have in fact been refunded in the past.

When clicking on individual pensions, there are icons to explain the differences between different types of retirement savings. There are also links to guidance from the Money and Pensions Service (Maps) on pensions, retirement living standards, consolidation and more.

In my case, the dashboard delivers as intended. The experience is slick, visually intuitive and reminiscent of the financial services we use every day like online banking. I found it as digestible, if not more, than the digital provision I have seen from my own pension provider.

Teething problems

This phase is designed to "refine the service and optimise based on user insight", rooting out remaining issues, and [in a much-viewed LinkedIn post](#), Scottish Widows workplace savings engagement and innovation specialist Robert Cochran has outlined a few.

He received an overinflated forecast for his retirement income, owing to inactive DB policies and DC pots showing up over time in his dashboard, some with out-of-date values.

Inaccurate retirement income predictions like Cochran's raise concerns that savers could be given a false sense of security when it comes to their retirement planning.

Speaking on a TPR podcast, [Pensions Dashboard Programme principal Chris Curry said](#) that standards in the industry had improved significantly as a result of the programme, and there has undoubtedly been progress when it comes to data quality and integration.

But as is to be expected for an industry-wide initiative at this scale, there has been a flurry of warnings from all quarters about administrator unpreparedness, surges in member enquiries, the burden on smaller schemes and more.

Unlike so much of the work into improving member outcomes and engagement, which remains largely invisible to the end user, the pensions dashboard represents a step change in how people can view their pensions.

But as PensionPay [senior operations associate Archie Pritchett argued in PP](#), the real test will be measurable changes in member behaviour, be that increased contributions, small pot consolidation, uptake of targeted support or improved comprehension.

The MHPD [is expected to launch in 2027/28](#).

Alex Levy is a reporter on *Professional Pensions*

To sign in to test the MHPD yourself, click [here](#).

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